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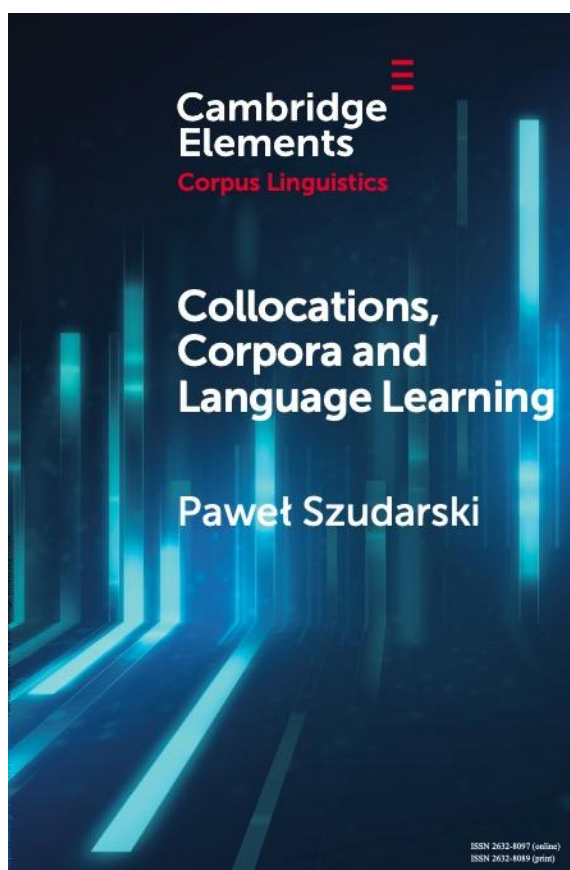
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Book Review

Collocations, Corpora and Language Learning, by Paweł Szubanski, Cambridge University Press, 2023, 89 pp., US\$ 20 (Paperback), ISBN: 978-1-108-99479-8 (Paperback)



Collocations play a significant role in language acquisition and instruction; appropriate use of collocations fosters idiomatic and fluent language production (Fernandez & Schmitt, 2015). Recent decades have witnessed a burgeoning interest in researching collocations in second language (L2) acquisition and applied linguistics. This growing trend is catalyzed in part by the great strides made in corpus linguistics. For example, notable improvements in accessibility to large corpora like the Corpus of Contemporary American English, along with the availability of corpus tools such as Sketch Engine, have enabled researchers to extract a substantial quantity of collocations used in various genres for pedagogical purposes.

The monograph entitled *Collocations, Corpora and Language Learning* by Paweł Szubanski synergizes the above research areas by furnishing an extensive and updated review of existing corpus-based collocation research. It covers the conceptual, methodological, and pedagogical aspects of collocations, including definition (Chapter 2), identification (Chapter 3), and pedagogical applications (Chapter 4), and also outlines future directions (Chapter 5). As such, it emerges as an essential reference guide for those who seek a

systematic understanding of collocations as pedagogical resources.

Chapter 1 begins by acknowledging the pivotal role that corpora play in studying collocations and setting forth two overarching objectives of this book; that is, “offering a critical synthesis of the current findings and pointing to key methodological considerations” (p. 1). It then proceeds with seven questions addressed by this book such as the definition and scope of collocations, corpus-informed pedagogical material development, and



L2 proficiency-dependent collocation use and assessment, while also providing an overview of the remaining chapters.

Chapter 2 discusses the conceptualization of collocations. Szubanski first introduces the patterned nature of language, the idiom principle, and lexio-grammar (i.e., the inseparability of grammar and lexis), and problematizes the criteria inconsistently employed in previous research to define collocations. Given that linguistic knowledge and use are often viewed as “a formulaic-creative continuum” (p. 7), he endorses collocations as a graded category of formulaic language. This means that the degree of collocability rather than the clear-cut binary category (either collocations or non-collocations) bears greater significance, as it is the degree of collocability that points to the graded nature of collocations.

Szubanski then critically reviews three main approaches to defining collocations, including the phraseological, the frequency-based, and the hybrid approaches. Specifically, the phraseological approach incorporates linguistic or semantic considerations such as restrictedness and transparency into assessing collocability. This entails human intuitive judgment and may lead to potential inconsistencies across studies. The frequency approach, on the other hand, features exclusively corpus-derived information. While it is objective, it likely generates collocations of limited usefulness for pedagogy, since it lumps linguistic units together without considering whether the collocations are challenging to L2 learners. The hybrid approach combines the phraseological and the frequency-based approaches to overcome some of the limitations inherent in each approach. It draws on frequency information to extract collocations and then applies linguistic criteria to refine the resulting units, such that the generated collocations are both frequent and linguistically meaningful. Despite the overwhelming strengths of the third approach, the phraseological or frequency-based approach may be still preferable depending on how collocations are operationalized within a study. This chapter concludes with a call for caution in exploiting corpus-derived information, as it may not precisely capture learners’ enriched sources of real-world language exposure and use.

Chapter 3 covers analysis methods and identifies appropriate measures of collocations. Two methods of analysis are broadly identified, quantitative and qualitative methodology. For a given word, the former may inspect the distribution of its collocates based on their frequency, while the latter explores the contextual use of those collocates. Ideally, the two methods can be integrated in a meaningful way to offer a more holistic explanation of a particular collocation use.

This chapter then reviews a variety of collocation measures used in corpus linguistics. These measures are categorized according to their functions, including statistical significance tests (t-score, log-likelihood test, and chi-square test), measures of association strength (Mutual Information and Log Dice), measures of exclusivity (Delta P), and measures of dispersion (Cohen’s d). The strengths and limitations of each measure are fully discussed. For example, the t-score favors high-frequency collocations, whereas Mutual Information prioritizes low-frequency ones. Both the t-score and Mutual Information are unidirectional measures. Delta P addresses this shortcoming by considering the dual direction (forward and backward) of collocations. Due to the inherent limitations of individual measures, researchers are encouraged to employ a combination of measures to capture the multifaceted nature of collocations. The chapter concludes by demonstrating how concordancing, a qualitative corpus analysis technique, can be profitably combined with frequency data to describe collocations in a “comprehensive, context-appropriate, and ecologically valid manner” (p. 42).

Chapter 4 orients readers to an overview of the usage-based theories, the main pedagogical insights gained from corpus-based collocation research, and their applications in L2 classrooms. The first section points to usage-based approaches to language acquisition as the theoretical underpinning that influences most corpus-based work into collocations, as individuals’ L2 experience plays a crucial role in “the creation, entrenchment, and processing of linguistic patterns” (p. 43). The second section reviews learner corpora research instrumental

to the understanding of interlanguage and learner variability. Specifically, it is dedicated to L2 collocations as a proxy for global language proficiency as well as the three strands of L2 collocational use (i.e., amount, accuracy and appropriacy, and automaticity), contrastive interlanguage analysis, and L2 collocational richness and sophistication as important linguistic indices to assess output quality. The last section discusses multiple ways in which corpus insights can be applied to teaching L2 collocations. For instance, corpora can be *indirectly* utilized to inform material development (e.g., creating collocation lists), and can also be *directly* adopted as a pedagogical technique (i.e., data-driven learning). Several corpus interfaces that embrace the use of technology are also introduced.

In closing, Chapter 5 highlights several ways that corpora have transformed how linguistic research has been undertaken and the importance of linguistic description and interpretation in corpus work. It then points out four promising research avenues of corpus-based collocation studies, including exploring individual trajectories, using mixed methods and interdisciplinary designs, bridging the gap between research and practice, and conducting replication studies.

Overall, this volume boasts several impressive features. First, it provides a state-of-the-art review synthesizing the strands of corpus linguistics, vocabulary studies, and L2 learning and teaching, which enriches our understanding of the pivotal role of corpora in contemporary L2 classrooms. Of special note, it reviews comprehensively, albeit briefly, the current practices of defining and measuring collocations in Chapters 2 and 3, identified as “recurring challenges” (p. 74). While we recognize that these two aspects have been reviewed elsewhere (e.g., Gablasova et al., 2017), the accompanying illustrative examples in this book are added bonuses, to which interested readers can refer for a meaningful understanding of these issues. Additionally, it also paves the way ahead by suggesting a few under-explored territories in Chapter 5, inspiring more thorough, innovative, pedagogically practical, and rigorous corpus-based investigations of collocations.

The second merit relates to its abandonment of the simple dichotomy of *native* and *non-native*; it encourages the use of such labels as *first language (L1)* and *target-like* in lieu of *native* and *nativelike* (see p. 46). Refraining from treating L1 use as the default position, this reframing practice reconceptualizes L2 under-performance as *difference* rather than *deficiency* and thus constitutes a welcoming endeavor in light of the ongoing decolonial orientation in English education (Kumaravadivelu, 2016). By extension, corpus researchers are advised to rethink the use of academic phrases as a function of *experience or practice* as opposed to *L1/L2 status* (p. 57). Specifically, as academic writing competence develops through practice and authentic experience, the distinctions between novice versus expert academic users are more significant compared to those between the L1 and L2 status. We are pleased to read these renewed perspectives, which are applicable to research areas beyond vocabulary. The third virtue pertains to its practical focus, as Chapter 4 transitions progressively from theories to research findings to pedagogical applications, thus narrowing the divide between theorists and practitioners. The final feature involves the quotations embedded throughout the text. These quotations derive from influential scholars in corpus linguistics and L2 learning such as John Firth, John Sinclair, and Nick Ellis, which allow for a deep engagement with the concepts presented in the book.

There are areas for refinement, nevertheless. First, to enhance readability, it would be useful to incorporate a detailed table of contents that clearly outlines each section and subsection to facilitate the navigation of the content. Second, the rearrangement of several subsections could potentially improve the coherence of the book. Specifically, Subsections 4.3.2 (Corpus-Based Lists of Collocations) and 4.3.3 (Corpus- and Technology-Enhanced L2 Teaching Resources), both reflecting the indirect utilization of corpora, should be situated within Subsection 4.3.1 (Indirect Impact of Corpora on Teaching L2 Collocations). These three subsections standing parallel to Subsection 4.3.4 (Data-Driven Learning and Collocations), which explicitly addresses the direct use of corpora data, may cause confusion. Third, given the book’s primary emphasis on collocation learning, a

wider range of resources capitalizing on the advances in corpus linguistics and technology should be provided to meet learners' diverse needs. In addition to the two tools introduced (IdiomsTube and ColloCaid), other popular alternatives, such as Sketch Engine for Language Learning (SKELL), Linggle, and Hyper Collocation, are also worth mentioning.

Overall, the volume makes a valuable contribution to corpus-based collocation research, showcasing an array of conceptual, methodological, and practical matters. It also reveals the complexity of this research strand. For example, while explored extensively, how collocations are defined and measured needs to be determined on a case-by-case basis due to a lack of one universal approach. As such, the book is well poised for novice researchers who strive to have a deep understanding of collocations to cognize complex linguistic phenomena, and practitioners including language teachers, textbook writers, and dictionary compilers who seek theoretical underpinnings for their practical decisions. Experienced researchers who wish to further their research agenda will also benefit from the future directions addressed in the book.

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Hanzhong Sun

School of Education, University of Cincinnati, USA

Email: sunhz@mail.uc.edu

Hye K. Pae

School of Education, University of Cincinnati, USA

Email: hye.pae@uc.edu

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